Kingfall: a one-player lane duel with a standard deck

Players: 1 · **Time:** 10–20 minutes · **You need:** one standard 52-card deck (no jokers). No pen, no counters, no dice.

Goal: destroy the enemy's king tower before it destroys yours. You play against an automaton: a simple, fixed set of rules runs the enemy, so you never have to make decisions for it.

Every card is a soldier. You spend elixir to send soldiers down two lanes, the enemy sends one card a round, they clash in the middle, and survivors attack the towers. Skill gives a big edge; luck still decides some games. A careful player wins most games, but not all.

Companion app (optional): the table guide runs the enemy for you and tells you exactly what to move each step. The rules below are complete without it.

Rank: A=1, 2–10 face value, J=11, Q=12, K=13. Suits only matter for the wheel (below).

Cost table (elixir)

Rank	A	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	J	Q	K
Cost	1	2	2	3	4	5	5	6	7	8	8	9	10

Suit wheel

In a fight (and a tower hit, which is a fight too), a card **counts double** against the suit it beats: ♠ beats ♥ · ♥ beats ♦ · ♦ beats ♣ · ♣ beats ♠. Example: 6♠ against J♥ fights as 12 and wins; against Q♥ it ties. Between ♠ and ♦ (or ♥ and ♣) nobody doubles.

Aces beat picture cards

In a fight, an **ace beats a J, Q or K**, whatever the suits. It works both ways: an enemy ace kills your king. It counts against towers too: an ace on top of a tower stops any picture card.

Setup (52 = 14 + 14 + 10 + 14 in the box)

1. Shuffle. Deal **14 to you**, **14 to the enemy** (face-down, don't look), then **10 face-down in a row for your elixir bar**. Put the **other 14 back in the box without looking**: they sit this game out, so you can never be sure which cards the enemy has.
2. **Your 14:** look at them. Choose **8 as your deck**; the other 6 are your **towers**: **left princess (2 cards)**, **right princess (2)**, **king (2)**. You choose the order of each stack; the top card is hit first.
   - Tip: any kind of deck can win. In testing, all-cheap, mixed and all-heavy decks win about as often; how you play decides the game.
3. Shuffle your 8 deck cards. Take 4 as your **hand**; the other 4 are your **queue** (face-down pile).
4. **Enemy 14:** without looking, shuffle them. 8 form its **pile** (face-down); 6 form its towers (**2 / 2 / 2**), face-down. Turn the **top card of its pile face-up**: the enemy's top card is always face-up, so you always know its next play.

5. **Elixir:** lay your bar as a row of 10 face-down cards with a small gap after the 5th, so positions read at a glance. Turn the **5th card sideways** (still face-down). That sideways card is the **marker**: elixir = its position, counted from the left (1–10). No card sideways = 0 elixir.
   - To gain or spend elixir, straighten the marker and turn the card that many places right or left sideways instead. Never past 10.
   - Tip: do the sums in your head and move the marker **once per round**: your new elixir = min(10, old + 3) − what you spent.
   - The enemy has **no elixir bar**: it plays one card per round.
6. **Table:** two lanes (left, right) between the tower rows. Each lane has **2 slots**: slot 1 next to you, slot 2 next to the enemy. Several cards may share a slot. Cards in a lane are **units**.

Each round

1. **Elixir.** Your marker moves **3** to the right. Max 10.
2. **You play.** As many cards as you like and can afford: move your marker left by the cost, put the card in **slot 1** of a lane, refill your hand to 4 from the top of your queue. You may play nothing.
3. **Enemy plays (automaton).** It plays **exactly one card**: its face-up top card, whatever it costs. The card goes to **slot 2 of the lane where you have more units** (tie: left), so the enemy always defends against your biggest push. Then turn its next top card face-up: that is its play next round.
4. **Move.** Every unit steps one slot toward the other side, **except** front units that already face each other (same slot or neighbouring slots): they don't move, they clash in place. Cards never pass through each other. A unit that steps past the last slot is **at the tower**. Units already at a tower stay there.
5. **Fight.** In each lane with units from both sides, your front-most unit fights the enemy's front-most (front-most = furthest advanced; tie: placed first). Compare rank, doubled for the winning suit (an ace against a picture card always wins).
   - **Higher wins; the loser goes to the bottom of its owner's pile** (the enemy's goes face-up: you know it now). **Equal:** both go.
   - The winner steps forward into the slot it cleared (if no other enemy card is still in the way) and fights the next enemy card, until one side has no units left in that lane.
   - Whenever one of your cards returns to your queue, refill your hand to 4.
6. **Tower hits.** Every unit at the tower hits that lane's princess stack, or the king stack if that princess stack is empty. **The king can only be hit once that lane's princess stack is gone.** Turn the top tower card face-up: **a tower hit is a fight** against that card, with the same rules (the wheel doubles, an ace beats a picture card).
   - The unit **wins or ties**, **or the card is already cracked (sideways)**: **the tower card is destroyed** (discard it). The unit stays at the tower, **turned sideways: it is wounded**. It hits **once more** next round (unless an enemy unit beats it first: it is the front-most unit in its lane, so new enemy cards fight it first), then goes to the bottom of its owner's pile whatever happens. So one card breaks at most 2 tower cards.
   - The unit **loses**: the tower holds and **shoots it back**: the unit goes to the bottom of its owner's pile, and the tower card **cracks**: turn it **sideways** and move it to the **bottom of that tower** (face-up if it is an enemy card). The next card is now on top. Any later hit breaks a cracked card, so every tower can be worn down, even by small cards.
   - The enemy hits your towers the same way. You know your own cards.
   - **Last stand:** when a left or right tower loses its last card, its owner immediately places **one card in that lane for free** (the marker doesn't move). You pick any card from your hand, put it in slot 1 and refill your hand. The enemy puts its face-up top card in slot 2, then turns its next top card face-up. The king has no last stand.
7. **End.** Enemy king stack empty = **you win**. Yours empty = **you lose**. Both in the same round = draw. Otherwise start the next round.

Designer's notes (from thousands of simulated games)

- Expect to lose your first games. Random play wins about 10%, a simple rule-follower about 50%, the companion app's suggestions about 80%. Thoughtless play mostly loses; thinking wins.
- What wins: clear enemy cards from your towers fast, push a lane when the enemy's face-up next card can't beat what you send, and stack your towers with care: a tower's top card fights back, so a heart on top stops diamonds and an ace on top stops picture cards.
- No single card decides a game: towers shoot back, so even a king breaks at most 2 tower cards before it goes home. Taking a king tower always needs a second attacker.
- Games last about 12–17 rounds; a long one runs to about 22.
- Every game is winnable: cracked tower cards mean no deck is ever stuck against towers it can't break.
- Skill is in the playing, not the deck: with a strong bot every deck type (all-cheap, mixed, all-heavy) wins about 70–82%, and a simple player copying the best deck wins less than a strong player with the worst one. Aces kill picture cards, and the wheel lets a mid card beat a big one.
- No numbers to memorise: the wheel doubles, aces beat pictures.
- Last stand makes comebacks more common: when a side tower falls, its owner gets a free card in that lane.
- Dead cards return to the bottom of their owner's pile, so your 8 cards keep cycling and you will face the enemy's cards again. A card holding a tower is out of that cycle until it dies.